HINDUSTAN INTERNATIONAL SCHOOL
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Karapakkam

HIS GLOBAL CONCLAVE – EDITION 3.0

"Where Young Minds Meet to Debate, Deliberate and Lead."

TAMIL NADU LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY (TNLA)

BACKGROUND GUIDE

Agenda: Discussion on the Central Delimitation Policy

Sustainable Development Goal: SDG 10 – Reduced Inequalities

Focus: Examining delimitation, political representation, federalism and their implications for equitable governance in India, with particular emphasis on Tamil Nadu.

LETTER TO DELEGATES

Dear Delegates,

We extend our warmest regards to all delegates representing the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly at HIS Global Conclave – Edition 3.0.

We invite you to engage with a significant constitutional and political issue facing India: the Central Delimitation Policy and its implications for political representation, federalism and equality.

Democracy is founded on the principle that every citizen must have a meaningful voice in the institutions that govern them. In a diverse country such as India, ensuring fair representation requires careful consideration of population distribution, constitutional provisions and the relationship between the Union and the States. Delimitation, which involves determining electoral constituency boundaries and, where constitutionally authorised, readjusting legislative representation, plays an important role in maintaining representative democracy.

The issue has particular significance for Tamil Nadu, which has expressed concerns about the possible effects of population-based redistribution of parliamentary seats on the State's relative representation in national decision-

making. These concerns are closely connected to population stabilisation, regional development and the principles of cooperative federalism.

At the same time, ensuring fair representation for citizens across all regions remains an essential democratic objective. The challenge is to examine how electoral reforms can maintain equality among voters while protecting the interests of States and preserving public confidence in India's federal structure.

As delegates of this committee, you are expected to analyse the constitutional, political and socioeconomic dimensions of delimitation. You should examine different perspectives, question existing approaches and develop practical recommendations that balance electoral equality with equitable regional representation.

This agenda is closely aligned with Sustainable Development Goal 10 – Reduced Inequalities, which promotes inclusion, equal opportunity and the reduction of inequalities within and among societies.

We encourage you to approach the committee with informed arguments, critical thinking, constructive debate and respect for differing viewpoints. Your participation should contribute to a deeper understanding of how democratic institutions can remain fair, inclusive and responsive to the needs of citizens.

The Executive Board looks forward to your research, participation and commitment throughout the session.

Sincerely,

Chairperson and Vice Chairperson
Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly (TNLA)

HISTORY OF THE COMMITTEE

TNLA – The Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly

The Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly is the elected legislative body of the State of Tamil Nadu. It is responsible for making laws on matters within the State's legislative jurisdiction, debating public policies, approving government expenditure and holding the State executive accountable.

The Assembly serves as an important platform through which elected representatives communicate the concerns of citizens, discuss regional

development and participate in the democratic process. Tamil Nadu has a significant history of legislative engagement with issues concerning social justice, education, welfare, regional identity and State autonomy.

The Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly operates within the constitutional framework of India. Although it cannot independently determine the allocation of seats in the Lok Sabha, it can debate the implications of national policies for Tamil Nadu and adopt resolutions expressing the State's concerns and recommendations.

The present agenda places the TNLA at the centre of a legislative simulation examining the Central Delimitation Policy. Delegates will represent legislative perspectives and consider how changes to electoral representation could affect Tamil Nadu's political influence, governance and relationship with the Union Government.

Delimitation in India

Since independence, India has relied on representative institutions to ensure that citizens participate in the democratic process through elected representatives. As population distribution changes, electoral boundaries and representation arrangements require consideration to maintain effective and equitable representation.

Delimitation Commissions have been established under parliamentary legislation to undertake electoral boundary readjustments. Their work has been shaped by constitutional provisions, census figures and the legal framework governing representation.

The 42nd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1976, froze the allocation of parliamentary seats among States and the total number of seats in State Legislative Assemblies on the basis of the 1971 Census. The 84th Constitutional Amendment Act, 2001, extended the freeze on the allocation of seats among States until the publication of the relevant figures of the first census taken after 2026, while permitting constituency boundary readjustments within the applicable constitutional framework. The 87th Constitutional Amendment Act, 2003, substituted the 2001 Census for the 1991 Census in the relevant provisions governing constituency readjustment.

These provisions were connected to concerns that States should not be disadvantaged in political representation because of their efforts to stabilise population growth.

As India continues to experience demographic change, the question of how future delimitation should be conducted has become an important subject of constitutional and political debate.

INTRODUCTION TO THE AGENDA

Agenda: Discussion on the Central Delimitation Policy

Delimitation refers to the process of determining the boundaries of electoral constituencies and, where authorised by the Constitution and applicable legislation, readjusting the allocation of seats in representative institutions.

In India, delimitation is closely connected to population distribution and the principle of electoral equality. Its purpose is to maintain appropriately defined constituencies and ensure that citizens have meaningful representation in legislative institutions.

However, delimitation also raises questions about the distribution of political influence among States. Since India's States have experienced different rates of population growth, a future redistribution of parliamentary seats could alter their relative representation in the Lok Sabha.

Tamil Nadu and other southern States have expressed concerns that a predominantly population-based approach could affect their relative influence in national decision-making despite their progress in population stabilisation and socioeconomic development.

The debate therefore involves two important principles: equal representation for individual citizens and fairness in the distribution of political influence among States.

The committee must examine how these principles can be reconciled within India's constitutional framework.

Understanding the Central Delimitation Policy

The Central Delimitation Policy, as considered in this committee, refers to the national constitutional framework, legislation and policy proposals governing the readjustment of electoral constituencies and parliamentary representation.

Three aspects are particularly important.

First, constituency delimitation involves determining or redrawing electoral boundaries to reflect population distribution and other legally relevant considerations.

Second, the allocation of parliamentary seats among States concerns the number of representatives each State sends to the Lok Sabha under the applicable constitutional framework.

Third, delimitation within State Legislative Assemblies concerns the boundaries and representation of constituencies within individual States.

These processes are related but distinct. A change in constituency boundaries does not necessarily mean that the number of parliamentary seats allocated to a State will change.

Articles 81 and 82 of the Constitution of India are central to the composition of the Lok Sabha and the readjustment of parliamentary representation. Article 170 addresses the composition of State Legislative Assemblies and the readjustment of their constituencies.

Understanding these provisions is essential for delegates seeking to develop constitutionally informed recommendations.

Tamil Nadu's Position and Concerns

Tamil Nadu's concerns regarding delimitation are closely associated with population stabilisation, political representation and the preservation of federal balance.

The State has emphasised its progress in family planning, education, healthcare and socioeconomic development. Concerns have been raised that redistributing parliamentary seats primarily according to population could change Tamil Nadu's relative share of representation compared with States experiencing faster population growth.

Such a change could influence the State's relative presence in national legislative discussions and its participation in decisions concerning national policies and development priorities.

At the same time, population-based representation is supported by the principle that citizens should have reasonably equal representation. Constituencies with significantly different populations may create differences in the representative weight of individual votes.

The committee must therefore consider how electoral equality can be maintained without overlooking the concerns of States that have pursued population stabilisation.

Political Representation and Governance

Political representation is essential to democratic governance because it enables citizens to participate in decisions through elected representatives.

Members of Parliament debate legislation, scrutinise government decisions and participate in determining national priorities. The distribution of parliamentary seats therefore influences how different regions participate in national decision-making.

Delimitation can also affect the relationship between representatives and their constituents. Constituencies with very large populations may create practical challenges for representatives seeking to address local concerns and maintain meaningful communication with citizens.

Consequently, delimitation must be examined not only as a technical process of redrawing boundaries but also as a question involving democratic accountability, regional representation and the functioning of federal institutions.

The committee should explore approaches that maintain electoral fairness while protecting the legitimacy of India's representative system.

CONNECTION TO SDG 10 – REDUCED INEQUALITIES

Sustainable Development Goal 10, adopted by the United Nations in 2015 as part of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, aims to reduce inequality within and among countries.

SDG 10 promotes social, economic and political inclusion, equal opportunity and the reduction of inequalities of outcome.

In the context of delimitation, these principles provide a framework for examining whether electoral arrangements allow citizens and regions to participate meaningfully in democratic decision-making.

Political representation is an important dimension of inclusion. When electoral arrangements are perceived as unfair, concerns may arise regarding equal participation, regional influence and public confidence in democratic institutions.

The relationship between delimitation and SDG 10 can be understood through three key principles.

Political inclusion: Citizens across different regions should have meaningful opportunities to participate in democratic decision-making.

Equal opportunity: Electoral arrangements should promote fairness and avoid unjustified disadvantages for particular communities or regions.

Inclusive governance: Institutions should remain responsive to demographic changes while maintaining public confidence in the fairness of representation.

SDG 10 does not prescribe a specific electoral formula for India. Instead, it encourages delegates to evaluate how different approaches to delimitation may affect equality, inclusion and democratic participation.

Reference: United Nations – Sustainable Development Goal 10
https://sdgs.un.org/goals/goal10

KEY CONSTITUTIONAL PROVISIONS AND DEVELOPMENTS

1. Constitution of India, 1950

The Constitution establishes India's parliamentary democracy and federal structure. It defines the composition of Parliament and State Legislatures and provides the legal framework governing electoral representation.

Articles 81 and 82 concern the composition of the Lok Sabha and the readjustment of parliamentary representation. Article 170 concerns the composition of State Legislative Assemblies and the readjustment of their constituencies.

These provisions form the constitutional foundation for discussions concerning delimitation and political equality.

2. The 42nd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1976

The 42nd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1976, introduced a freeze on the allocation of parliamentary seats among States and the total number of seats in State Legislative Assemblies, based on the 1971 Census.

The measure was associated with national population-stabilisation objectives and sought to prevent States from losing relative representation solely because of their efforts to reduce population growth.

It remains an important historical development in understanding the concerns raised by Tamil Nadu and other States.

3. The 84th Constitutional Amendment Act, 2001

The 84th Constitutional Amendment Act, 2001, extended the freeze on the allocation of seats among States until the relevant figures of the first census taken after 2026, while permitting constituency boundary readjustments within the constitutional framework.

The amendment is important because it distinguishes the allocation of seats among States from the readjustment of constituency boundaries.

4. The Delimitation Act, 2002

The Delimitation Act, 2002, provided the statutory framework for the relevant delimitation exercise. The resulting constituency orders were finalised in 2008.

Delimitation Commissions provide a formal mechanism for electoral boundary decisions and operate under the applicable constitutional and legal framework.

The legislation is relevant to discussions about transparency, independent decision-making and the fair determination of electoral constituencies.

5. The 106th Constitutional Amendment Act, 2023

The Constitution (106th Amendment) Act, 2023, provides for the reservation of approximately one-third of seats for women in the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies, including the applicable reserved seats for women belonging to Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes.

The Act came into force on 16 April 2026. Its implementation is linked to a census conducted after the Act's commencement and the subsequent delimitation exercise specified in the Act.

This development highlights the connection between delimitation and inclusive political representation.

ROLE OF DELEGATES IN THE TNLA SIMULATION

Delegates will participate as Members of the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly and engage in a legislative discussion on the Central Delimitation Policy.

Participants are expected to research their assigned political positions, prepare evidence-based speeches and examine the constitutional implications of different proposals.

Delegates should raise questions concerning political representation, population stabilisation, federalism and equality. They are encouraged to propose amendments, negotiate with other participants and work towards a resolution that addresses the agenda.

The simulation should reflect the responsibilities of a legislative body: examining evidence, debating policy alternatives, considering competing interests and developing recommendations within constitutional boundaries.

Delegates must recognise that the TNLA cannot independently determine the allocation of seats in the Lok Sabha. Its role in this context is to deliberate on the implications for Tamil Nadu and express its position through appropriate legislative mechanisms.

CONCLUSION

Delimitation is an important democratic process that influences electoral representation, political equality and the relationship between the Union and the States.

For Tamil Nadu, the issue raises significant questions about the relationship between population stabilisation and political representation. At the same time, India's democratic system must ensure that citizens across all regions have meaningful and reasonably equal representation.

The challenge is to reconcile the principle of electoral equality with the need to maintain a balanced federal structure. Any proposed reform must be examined carefully in light of constitutional provisions, demographic realities and its potential consequences for governance.

SDG 10 – Reduced Inequalities provides a framework for considering how democratic institutions can promote political inclusion, equal opportunity and fair participation.

As delegates of the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly, participants have the opportunity to examine different perspectives, develop practical recommendations and contribute to a deeper understanding of India's democratic institutions.

Through informed debate, constructive negotiation and evidence-based policymaking, delegates can explore how future electoral reforms may strengthen democratic legitimacy, preserve public confidence and support inclusive governance.

The objective is not merely to determine how electoral constituencies should be drawn, but to consider how every citizen and every region can retain a meaningful voice in the democratic process.

Best of luck, delegates!

Regards,
The TNLA Executive Board
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